



The Wheel



Was the wheel one of the greatest inventions that changed the course of history? Possibly, it was. Without the invention of the wheel, the world's work might have to stop.

The Wheel

Think about what wheels are used for every day; in cars, trains, farm machines, and airplanes. We might still have to carry our heaviest loads on the backs of animals to get around, if we did not have the use of wheels.

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The wheel is a simple machine. It is a circle-shaped device that allows things to roll. As the wheel spins, the objects on the wheel move along the ground.

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We do not know exactly when wheels were invented. Some of the earliest evidence for the wheel dates back to 4000 BC in Mesopotamia, where wheels on a form of turntable were used for making pottery. Evidence for the earliest wheeled vehicles sits somewhere around 3500 BC. Before this, sleds or sledges with rollers were used to move large objects across the land.

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The first wheels would have been solid discs or sliced tree trunks. Spoked wheels were soon to follow. Spoked wheels allowed swifter and lighter vehicles to be constructed.

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Spoked wheels were composed of three key parts – the hub, the spokes and a rim. This type of wheel appeared in the Egyptian chariots, around 2000 BC. The Ancient Romans went on to develop variety in their wheeled vehicles. They built farm carts, chariots for war, hunting and racing, and even passenger coaches.

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Today, wheels are everywhere. You can find wheels in cars, airplanes, wheelchairs, bicycles, trains, caravans, and even roller skates. The wheel could be one of the greatest inventions of all time.

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